of life, an institutional approach vis-à-vis environment was found necessary. Hence, environmental law emerged as the sole option which could transact proper business in the realm of ecological equilibrium. Although the institutional manifestations and legal frameworks as an expression of international interests in the protection of environment is a 20th century product, the very germination of the seeds of environmental thought from an institutional perspective dates back to 1872 since the formation of a non-governmental congress of private citizens for the protection of nature. It later led to the establishment of a consultative commission at Berne to deal with international protection of nature. However, the First World War made the commission's activities futile. But, after the World War II, the commission was rechristened as the first intergovernmental body, with legal recognition, for environmental protection.

The Brunnen Conference for Protection of Nature in 1947, sponsored by the Swiss League, adopted a draft constitution for the International Union for the Protection of Nature. There has been further institutional evolution on environmental matters. As far as the UN is concerned, the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) is the only organ which directly works on environmental policies. Besides, around eight of the specialized bodies within the UN ambit also directly engage with environmental concerns. With the constitution of UN Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation (UNESCO) in 1945, the post-war phase gained a boost on building consensus on environmental issues. The second overture in this track with the establishment of International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) in 1948 which lifted the global environmental narrative to a higher trajectory.

Since then, efforts were accelerated on lines of crafting a set of international laws regarding environmental protection. Environmental law, in its policy dimension, is a collection of agreements, treaties, conventions, declarations, principles, opinions of jurists, practices and pertaining to mutual rights and obligations among states. The success of environmental law as method relies upon the cooperation and coordination among states by means of international responsibility on ecological considerations at any policy arena given.

12.2 Multilateral Conferences on Environment

Environmental diplomacy has become an important subset of internationalism in the 1970s. Numerous efforts, formally and informally, have been afoot to protect the environment at the international level. The United Nations (UN) remains the main impetus and driver of incorporating environmental concerns in this direction. A series of the important conferences as follows:

Ramsar Convention, 1971

The Convention on Wetlands, also called the Ramsar Convention, is an international treaty calling for "the conservation and wise use of all wetlands through local and national actions and international cooperation, as a contribution towards achieving sustainable development throughout the world". It was adopted at Ramsar, Iran in 1971 and came into force in 1975. The United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation (UNESCO) is the depository of the Convention. The Secretariat of Ramsar Convention is functioning within the headquarters of the International Union for the Conservation of Nature (IUCN) in Gland, Switzerland. On 21 August 2015,

12th_Political Science_Unit_12.indd 278 1/30/2020 4:18:45 PM